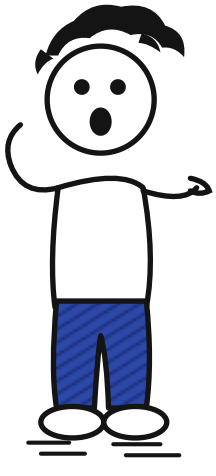
Claude is supposed to actually *work* now?
But I can't program.

And I have never once opened a terminal.



?

Folders

The plan

Spreadsheets

Slides

Connections

Projects

Permissions

Schedule

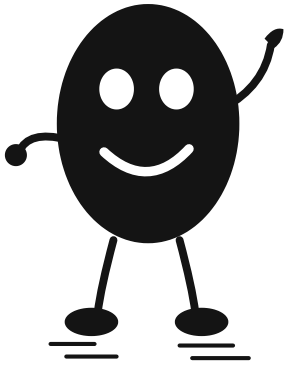
Safety

Helpers

Chrome

Skills

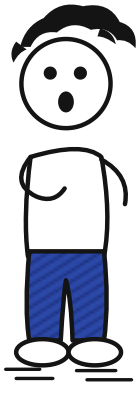
You don't need to.

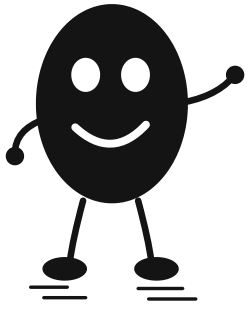


So – what is Cowork, actually?

The same machinery that sits behind Claude Code – but you use it in the ordinary Claude app. No terminal, nothing to set up.

It is meant for office work: research, analysis, producing documents. Anything that takes several steps.





Research | Analysis | Documents | Tidying up

↓

COWORK

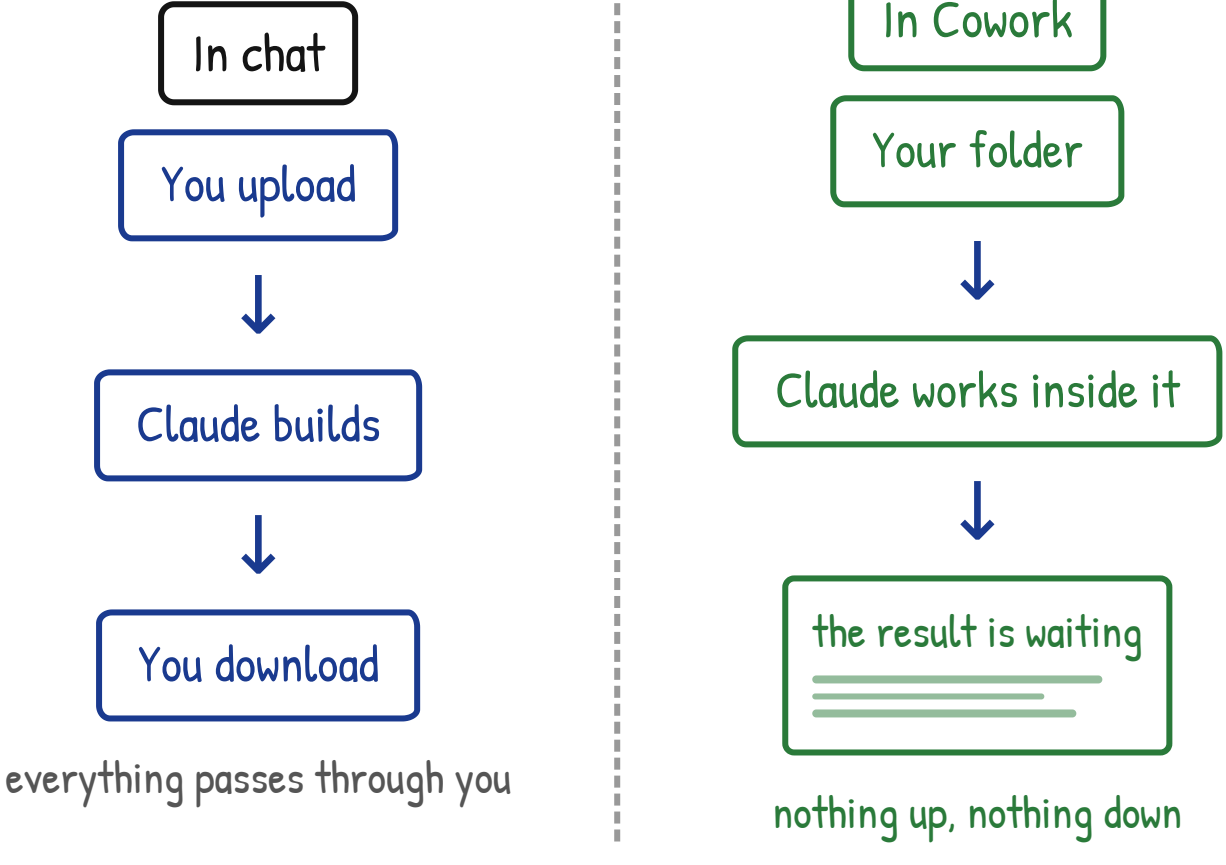
↓

the same machinery as Claude Code – just without a terminal

But I can already ask Claude questions?

Sure – and in chat you even get finished files. But they are built in a sealed-off area, and you download them yourself.

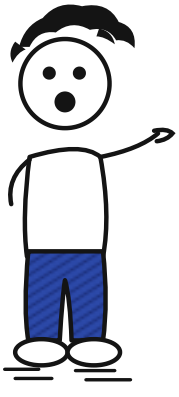
In Cowork, Claude works **directly in your folders**: it reads what is there and puts the result beside it. No uploading, no downloading.

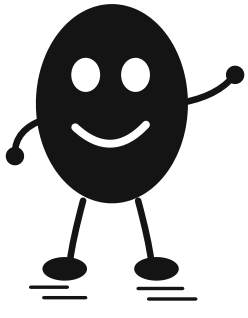


How do I get started?

Four steps. In the input box you switch from **Chat** to **Cowork**. If there is no switch, skip that – then every conversation can do it.

Then you describe what should come out. Claude shows you its plan. You look it over, and off it goes.





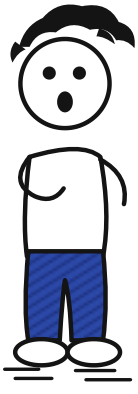
Chat | **Cowork**

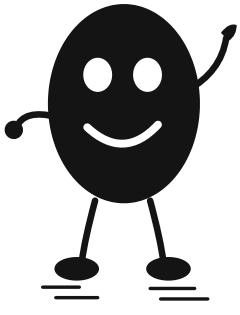
1 · Switch	from Chat to Cowork, if it is there
2 · Describe	"Sort out my downloads folder"
3 · Read the plan	Claude shows what it intends
4 · Let it run	watch – or come back later

Does it just get going, then?

No. Claude works out a plan first and shows it to you – before anything happens.

And while it works you see at every step what it is doing. No black box.





Your task

↓

Claude shows you first:

"I'll look at the 34 receipts, sort them by date, pull out the amounts and build a spreadsheet with a totals formula."

↓

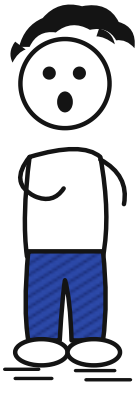
You approve

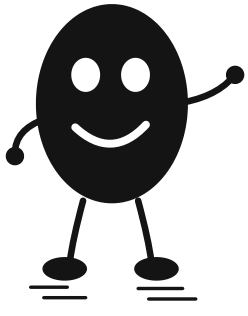
or you correct it

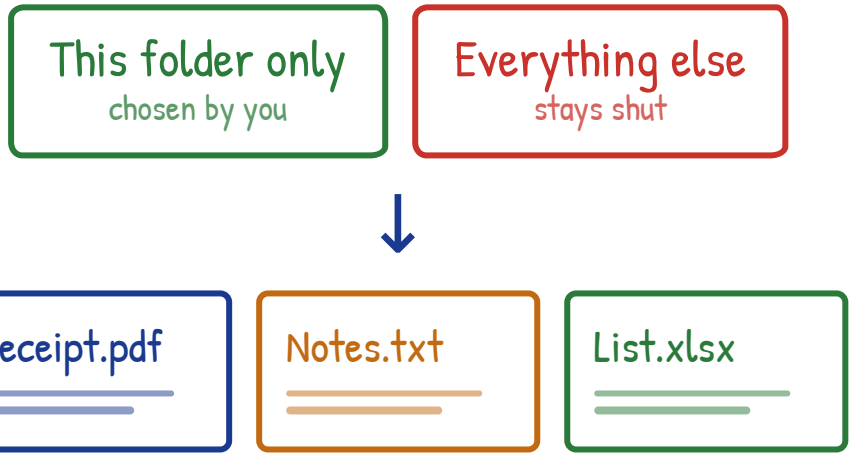
How does it know where my things are?

You share a folder with it. Claude then reads and writes directly inside it – you don't have to upload or download anything.

That works through the desktop app, only for the folders you picked, and only while the app is running.





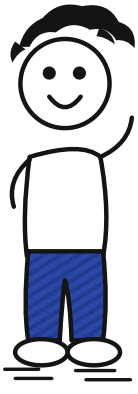


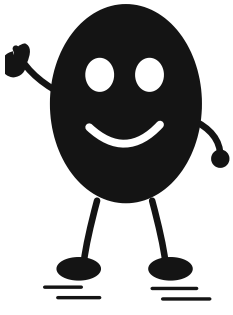
no uploading, no downloading – Claude works right inside it

And what do I get at the end?

Real files, not a wall of text for you to retype.

Spreadsheets with **working formulas**, presentations, neatly formatted documents. Ready to open and pass on.





Spreadsheet

Presentation

Report

with real formulas

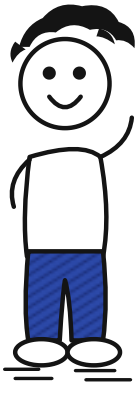
fully formatted

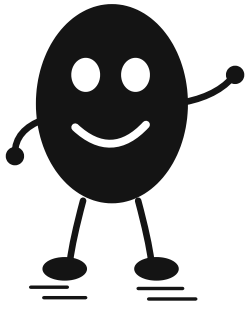
with its sources named

Give me some really concrete examples.

Sort the downloads folder by type and date. Turn a pile of receipt photos into a finished expense report.

Rename files to one scheme. Build a report out of notes. Pull together everything that matters before a meeting.





Sort the downloads folder

Receipts → expense report

Rename files
2026-08-13-invoice.pdf

Notes → report

Prepare for a meeting

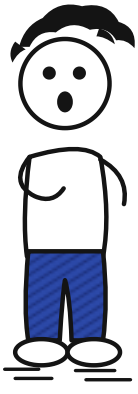
Summarise research

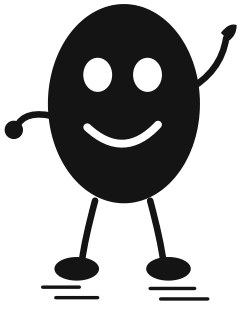
A report every week

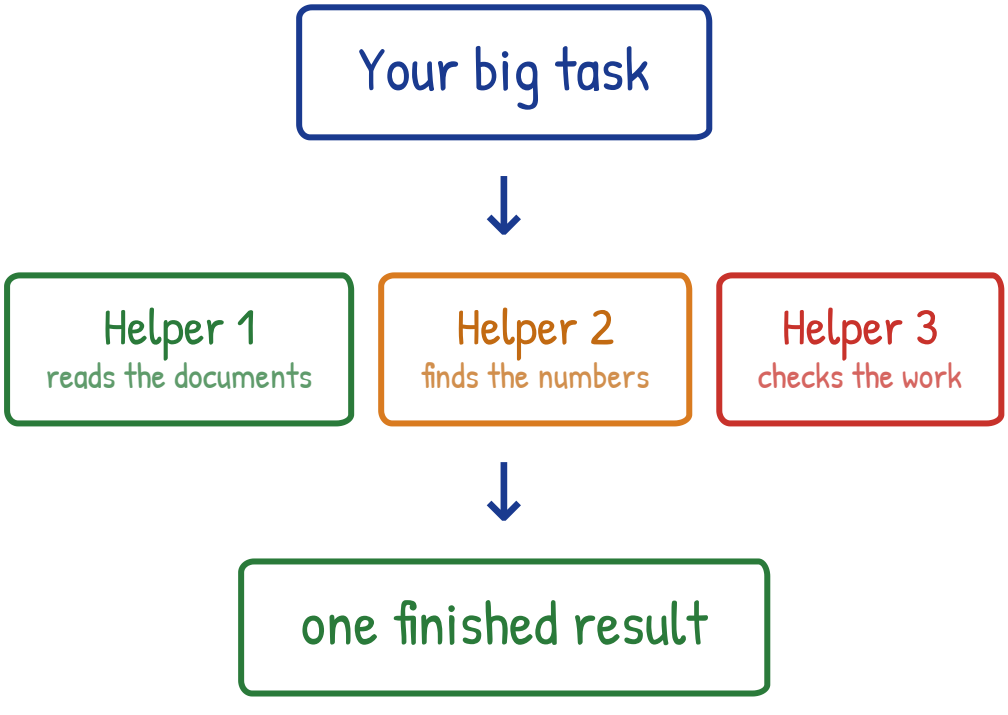
Big jobs must take forever, then?

Not necessarily. Claude splits big work into smaller pieces and runs several helpers at the same time.

Each does its part, and at the end everything is brought together.



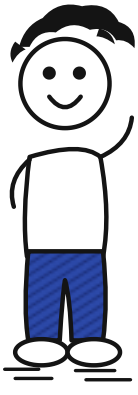


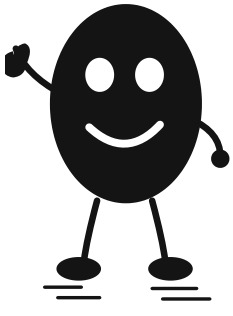


Do I have to sit and watch?

No. You can close the laptop – the job keeps running.

And you can reopen the same session somewhere else later: on your computer, in the browser or on your phone.





You start it → Laptop closed → Claude keeps working → You come back

↓

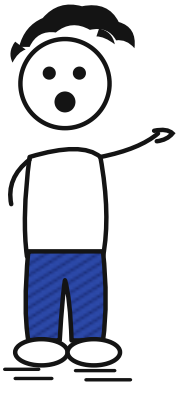
Desktop app | Browser | Phone

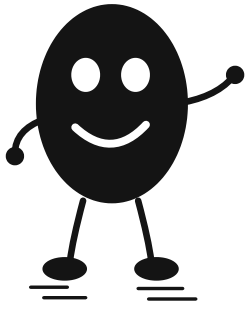
the same session, wherever you open it

You say phone – can I kick something off while I'm out?

Yes – just type the task into the phone app. The work carries on in the cloud, your computer may be switched off.

Only if Claude needs your folders on the computer does it have to be awake with the Claude app open. The former **Dispatch** is no longer offered to new users.





On the go → Type the task → Claude works → Pick up the result

Typed on the go, for example:

"Find me three hotels in Lisbon for the long weekend and make a comparison table."

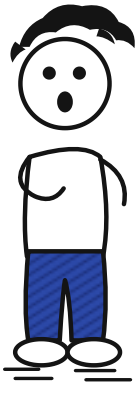
In the cloud
computer may be off

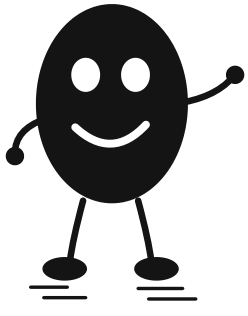
Your folders
only with computer awake + app

Can I bring some order to this?

Yes, with projects. Every project is its own workspace with its own files and its own instructions.

Inside one, Claude also remembers what it learned last time – you don't start from scratch every time.





Taxes 2026

- its own files
- its own instructions
- its own memory

Club

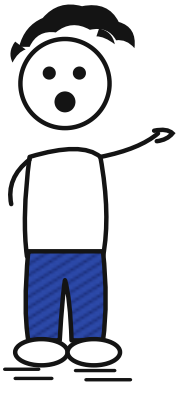
- its own files
- its own instructions
- its own memory

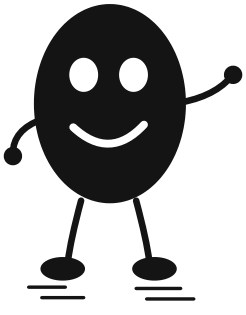
separate workspaces – nothing gets mixed up

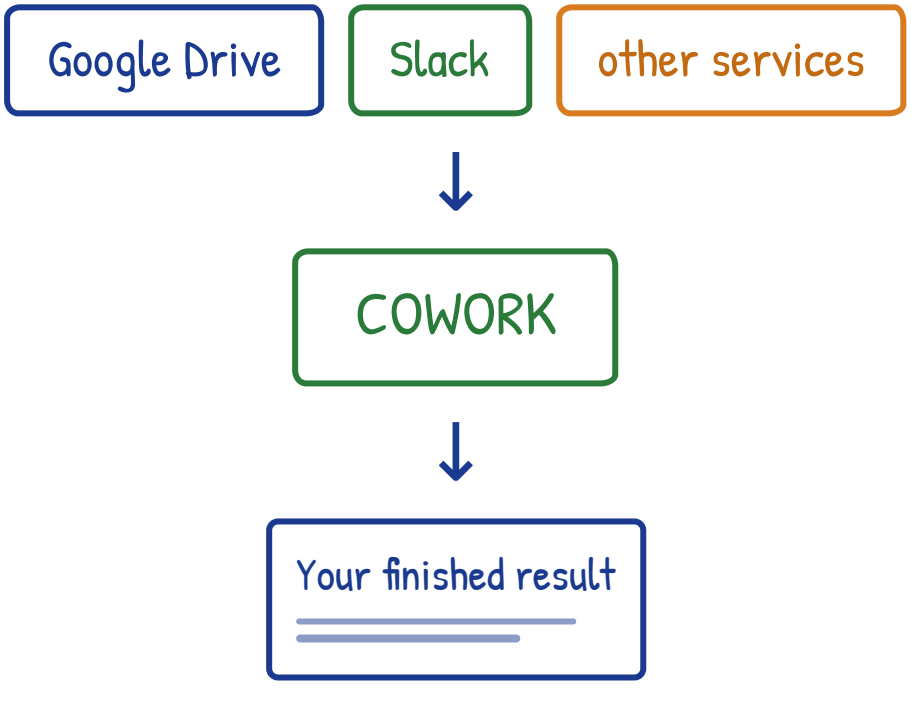
Can it reach my other programs too?

If you connect it, yes. You attach Google Drive, Slack and other services under **Customize** in the sidebar.

After that Claude fetches things itself – no more copying back and forth.



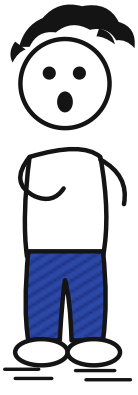


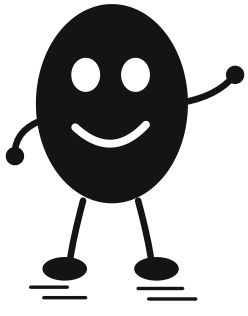


I've heard about "skills". Do I need them?

Not to begin with. A skill is a saved procedure for something you need the same way over and over.

There are ready-made bundles for whole professions. You switch those on under **Customize** as well.





Your instruction

Your procedure

Your example

↓

SKILL

↓

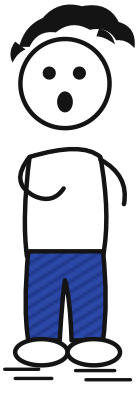
set it up once

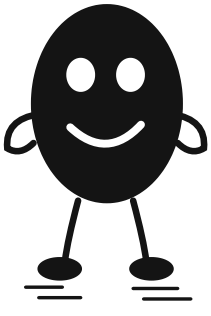
call it again and again

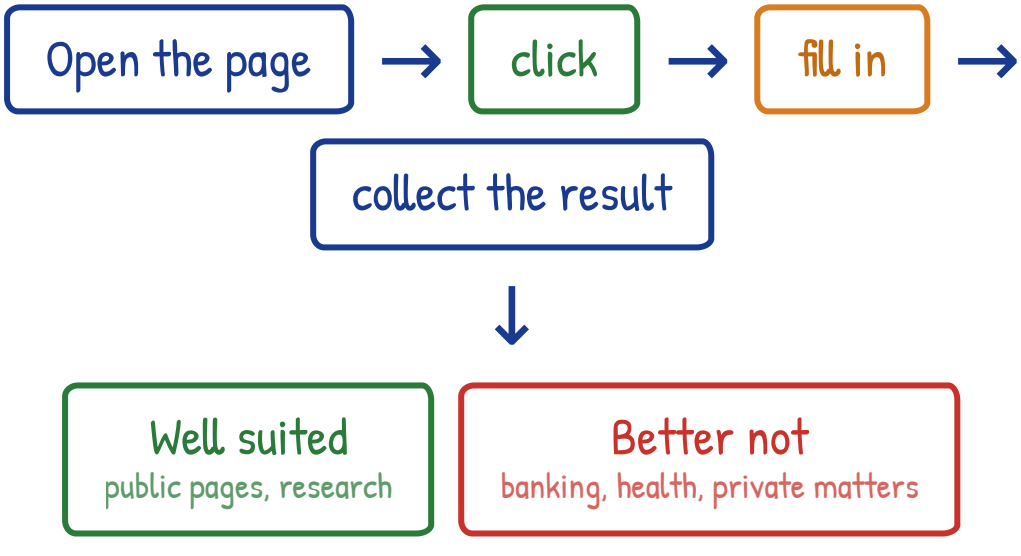
And what if something only works on a website?

Then Claude can use the browser too: clicking, typing, filling in forms.

That is handy – but that is exactly where I would be careful. Better not for banking, health and anything personal.



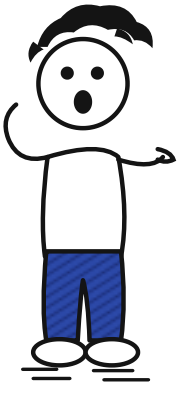


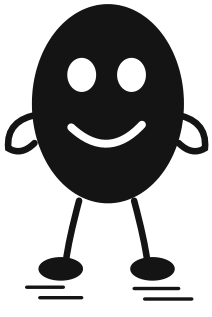


So may it simply do anything?

You decide how long the leash is. There are three levels, and Cowork starts on the most careful one: **Manual** is the default.

You switch levels in the chat box. The bottom level switches *all* the checks off – I would only use that one if you know exactly why.





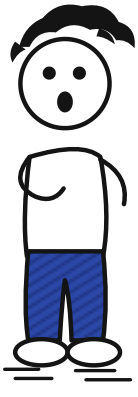
Manual	asks before every step, the default
Automatic	works straight through, checking itself for safety
No questions	never asks, nothing checks along – only with good reason

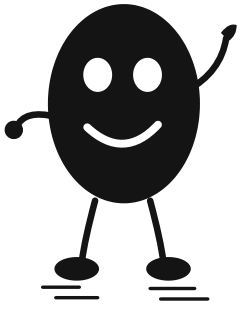
Claude may never delete for good without your explicit yes – at every level

Can it run regularly on its own, too?

Yes. Under **Scheduled** in the sidebar you set up recurring jobs. They run in the cloud, even while your computer sleeps – unless they need your folders.

Start with something harmless. And look in now and then to see what comes out.





Every Monday: weekly report from the project folder

↓

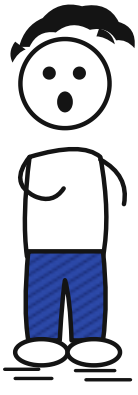
runs by itself → the result is waiting → you look it over

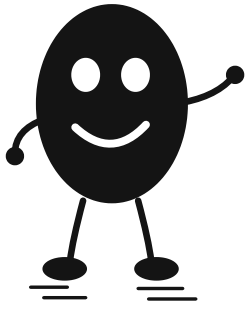
start with small, harmless jobs

Does all of this run on my computer?

No – the actual work happens sealed off on Anthropic's servers. It cannot reach your home network.

But careful with that line of thought: it protects your computer. It does **not** limit what Claude can do with whatever you shared with it.





Protected

Your computer

Your home network

it cannot reach these

Open all the same

shared folders

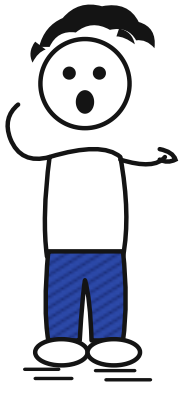
connected services

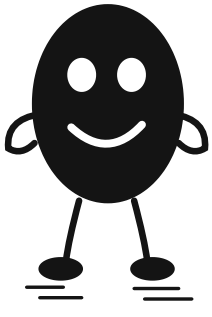
what you share is shared

Is there anything that can really go wrong?

The one that matters most: a web page, an e-mail or a document contains hidden instructions – and Claude reads them along the way while doing your job.

So: only pull in sources you trust. And with anything from outside, better use the **Manual** level.





someone else's web page → hidden instruction → Claude reads it too

↓

Check your sources
only what you know

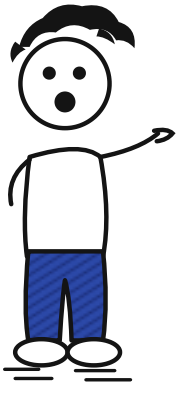
Switch to manual
for anything from outside

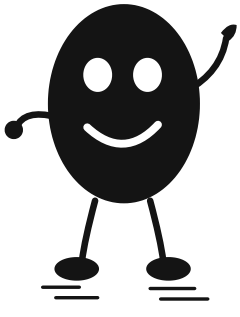
Look at the result
don't trust it blindly

What should I remember so nothing goes wrong?

Set up a working folder of its own instead of sharing everything. Keep backups. And leave financial papers, credentials and personal matters out of it.

You don't have to check every step – but do look at whether the whole thing seems plausible.



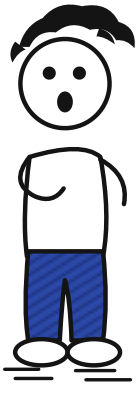


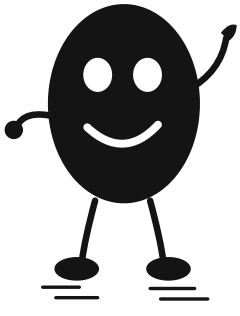
A folder of its own	share only what the job needs
Backups	of anything that hurts if it is gone
Start small	harmless jobs first, then the important ones
Leave out	finances, credentials, health, private matters

And when do I use the other one – Claude Code?

It depends on how far you let Claude at your things. Cowork is the middle stage: your folders, nothing else.

Claude Code is allowed onto the whole machine. In return you can teach it tools of your own – and it keeps running when you are not there.





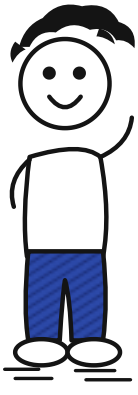
1 · In the conversation	nothing to set up – you upload, you download
2 · Cowork	you are here: Claude works in your folders
3 · Claude Code	terminal: the whole machine, your own tools, runs without you

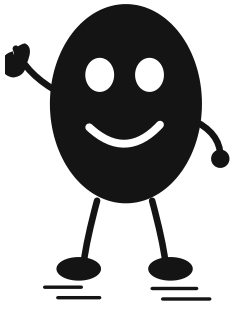
stages 1 and 3 each have a booklet of their own

And where do I find it?

In the Claude app: on the computer for Windows and Mac, in the browser and on your phone. On Pro and Max, Cowork is becoming part of every conversation – then with no switch.

It is part of the paid plans. If you already have one, it is simply there.





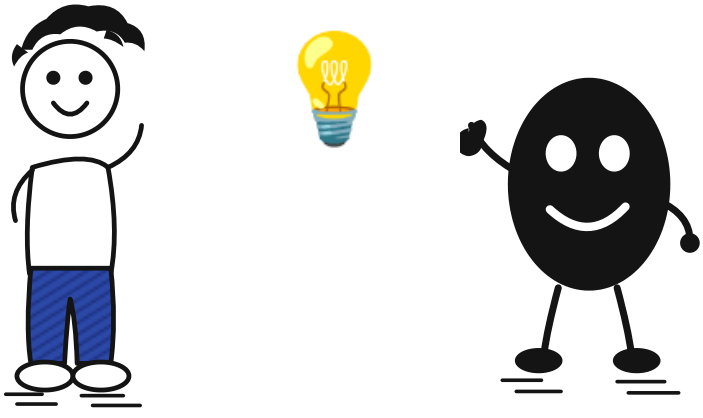
Chat | Cowork

Windows | Mac | Browser | Phone

included in the paid plans – as of October 2026

That sounds doable. I'll give it a try.

Just right. Start with the downloads folder.



Start – switch to Cowork, or just start typing
Describe – say what should come out, not how
Read the plan – Claude shows its intent first
Share a folder – only the one it is about
Result – finished spreadsheets, slides, documents
From your phone – type the task, it carries on in the cloud
Projects – separate workspaces with a memory
Connections – Drive, Slack and more under "Customize"
Permissions – three levels, you decide
On a schedule – under "Scheduled", runs in the cloud
Careful – outside content, finances, credentials
The three stages – how far Claude may go into your things